

Gambling

prc-gambling

Christian Ethics · Money · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Reached by general principle, not by a naming word
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

Gambling for gain at another's loss is unwise and contrary to neighbor-love; it is to be avoided as a regular practice.

In plain language

The proposition asks whether gambling for gain at another person's loss is unwise, contrary to loving a neighbor, and something to avoid as a habit. The first thing the words show is that no Greek or Hebrew term in the whole Bible means gambling, a wager, or a game of chance played for money. Any verdict has to be assembled from texts about money, work, and the lot, not read off a single word. The signal in those texts is consistent. In 1 Timothy 6 the danger is the settled wish to be rich, called a snare, and the rare word 'love of money' (philarguria) is called a root of all kinds of evils. Proverbs 13:11 sets wealth from 'vapor or emptiness' (hebel), which shrinks, against wealth gathered by hand, which grows. Proverbs 28:20 and 22 add the verbs 'to hasten' ('uts) and 'to be in haste' (bahal) for hurrying to be rich, and warn that the one in a hurry will not go unpunished. Ephesians 4:28 tells the former thief to labor with his own hands and produce something good so he has a surplus to share with someone in need. Together these favor patient earning, contentment, and giving over craving, shortcutting, and taking. That pattern leans toward the proposition. The honest reason the verdict is contested is a scope problem in the vocabulary, not a contradiction in the texts. The words address the disposition behind acquisition, the velocity of it, and the neighbor effect of it, but they do not name a wager, so the step from love of money or hasty wealth to gambling specifically is an application rather than a direct statement. Two further texts keep the question open. Proverbs 16:33 and Acts 1:26 treat the lot ('goral' in Hebrew, 'kleros' in Greek) as a decision-making instrument under God, never a commercial wager. The parable of the talents in Matthew 25 commends trading at risk for a return. The lexicon (dictionary of biblical word meanings) does not draw the line between sanctioned productive risk and a zero-sum wager taken from a neighbor. So the surrounding ethic is dense and spread across the whole Bible, but the target practice is unnamed, which is why honest readers land in different places on the same words.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0213	אץ	'uts	to hasten	10
H0926	בהל	bahal	to dismay	31
H1215	בצע	betsa	unjust-gain	22
H1486	גורל	goral	allotted	71
H1892	הבל	hebel	vanity	64
H1952	הון	hon	substance	25
H3068	יהוה	yehovah	LORD	
H4591	מעט	ma'at	to diminish	22

H5392	נִשְׁכַּח	neshekh	interest	
H6238	אֶשַׁר	ashar	to enrich	
H6908	קָבַט	qabats	to gather	119
G0018	ἀγαθός	agathos	good	
G0684	ἀπώλεια	apoleia	destruction	19
G1014	βούλομαι	boulomai	to plan	40
G1937	ἐπιθυμέω	epithumeō	to long for	
G1939	ἐπιθυμία	epithumia	desire	38
G2038	ἐργάζομαι	ergazomai	to work	41
G2770	κερδαίνω	kerdainō	to gain	
G2812	κλέπτῃς	kleptēs	thief	
G2813	κλέπτω	klepto	to steal	13
G2819	κλήρος	kleros	lot	12
G2872	κοπιᾶω	kopiao	to labor	24
G2975	λαγχάνω	lagchanō	to choose by lot	
G3330	μεταδίδωμι	metadidomi	to share	5
G3639	ὀλεθρός	olethros	destructive	4
G3713	ὀρέγω	orego	to aspire	3
G3803	παγίς	pagis	trap	5
G4123	πλεονέκτης	pleonektēs	greedy	
G4124	πλεονεξία	pleonexia	greediness	10
G4147	πλουτέω	pluteo	be rich	12
G4491	ρίζα	rhiza	root	17
G5365	φιλαργυρία	philarguria	love of money	1
G5366	φιλάργυρος	philarguros	money-loving	2

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

No Hebrew or Greek dictionary word (lemma, the base form of a word) in the canon names gambling, a wager, or a game of chance for money. The proposition is reached only by analogia scripturae (the principle of letting Scripture interpret Scripture by comparing related passages) from nearby money-ethics texts, and there the word-level signal is dense and consistent. The settled wish to be rich is condemned in 1 Timothy 6:9-10 by way of 'wishing to be rich' (boulomai-ploutein), 'craving' (epithumia), 'reaching out for' (orego), and 'love of money' (philarguria), which is a New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament). Wealth from emptiness is contrasted with wealth gathered by hand in Proverbs 13:11 by way of 'wealth' (hon), 'vapor or emptiness' (hebel), 'gathering by hand' (qabats-al-yad), and 'dwindling' (ma'at) versus 'increasing' (rabah). Hastening to be rich is censured in Proverbs 28:20-22 by way of 'hurrying' ('uts) and 'being in haste' (bahal), set alongside 'wealth' (hon) and the cognates of 'to be rich' (pluteo). The post-theft ethic is productive labor that yields a surplus to share in Ephesians 4:28 by way of 'stealing' (klepto), 'laboring hard' (kopiao), 'working' (ergazomai), 'the good' (agathon), and 'sharing' (metadidomi). That converging witness leans the application toward affirmation. Two complicating

patterns keep the verdict properly contested. In the canon the lot, 'goral' in Hebrew and 'kleros' in Greek, is consistently a decision-making or portion-assigning instrument under divine providence (Proverbs 16:33, Proverbs 18:18, Acts 1:26, and the allotment passages in Numbers and Joshua) and never a wager for gain, so it neither warrants nor forbids commercial chance. And trading at risk for return is commended in Matthew 25:16 by way of 'he traded with them' (ergazomai-en-autois). The words address the disposition, the velocity, the means, and the neighbor effect of acquisition, but they do not isolate gambling from other forms of acquisitive risk. The verdict is therefore disputed on scope grounds, with medium confidence because the surrounding ethic is pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) and stable even though the target practice is unnamed.

Scripture

1Tim.6.9 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1014 βούλομαι, G4147 πλουτέω, G1939 ἐπιθυμία, G3803 παγίς, G3639 ὀλεθρος, G0684 ἀπώλεια

Reasoning. 'Those resolving to be rich' (Hoi boulomenoi ploutein) fall into temptation and a snare and many senseless and harmful desires that sink human beings (anthropoi) into 'ruin and destruction' (olethron kai apoleian). The articular present participle (the 'the-ones-who-are-doing' form with the article 'the') 'resolving' (boulomenoi) names a settled act-of-the-will disposition, not a single transaction. The word-level weight rests on wanting wealth and its self-destructive end state, so any acquisition pattern driven by that disposition is caught, but the grammar does not single out one means.

1Tim.6.10 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G5365 φιλαργυρία, G3713 ὁρέγω, G4491 ῥίζα

Reasoning. 'Love of money' (Philarguria), a New Testament hapax legomenon (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament), is called 'a root of all kinds of evils' (rhiza panton ton kakon), and some 'reaching out for it' (oregomenoi) were led astray from the faith and pierced themselves with many pains. The hapax (only-once) status means the sense is anchored only by the cognate (related word from the same root) 'lover of money' (philarguros), found at Luke 16:14 and 2 Timothy 3:2 where it describes a settled love of money. The censure targets the affection itself. Gambling is reached only as one possible instance of that affection in action.

Prov.13.11 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H1952 הון, H1892 הֶבֶל, H6908 יָבֵן, H4591 מַעַט

Reasoning. 'Wealth from emptiness dwindles, but the one gathering by hand increases' (Hon mehebel yim'at we-qobets al-yad yarbeh). 'Wealth' (Hon) that comes from 'vapor or emptiness' (hebel) dwindles, while one who 'gathers by hand' (qobets al-yad) increases it. The proverb's two-line opposing structure pairs 'vapor' (hebel) against 'by hand' (al-yad), contrasting a quick or insubstantial source against patient hand-by-hand accumulation. 'Vapor or emptiness' (Hebel) is a general term for what is fleeting or insubstantial, used widely in Ecclesiastes and the prophets, not a gambling-specific word, so the principle reaches windfall acquisition broadly and gambling only by inclusion.

Eph.4.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2813 κλέπτω, G2872 κοπιάω, G2038 ἐργάζομαι, G0018 ἀγαθός, G3330 μεταδίδωμι

Reasoning. 'The one stealing must no longer steal' (Ho klepton meketi klepteto), but rather 'must labor working the good with his own hands' (kopiato ergazomenos tais idiais chersin to agathon), 'so that he may have to share with the one having need' (hina eche metadidonai to chreian echonti). The 'in-order-that' clause (hina clause, a purpose clause introduced by the Greek word for 'so that') sets the purpose of labor as surplus available for the neighbor, the inverse of acquisition that subtracts from a neighbor without producing value. The pattern condemns net transfer from a needy other and commends productive value creation, but does not name commercial chance as such.

Prov.28.20 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0213 אוץ, H6238 נָשַׁר

Reasoning. An expansion of the Proverbs 13:11 pattern. The faithful man abounds with blessings, but he who 'hastens' ('ats) to be rich will not go unpunished. The verb 'to hasten' ('uts) marks velocity of acquisition, not the means. Paired with Proverbs 28:22 where one with an evil eye 'hastens' (nivhal, the passive form of 'to be in haste') after wealth and does not know that want will come on him, the proverbial witness censures shortcut enrichment generally, with gambling as a clear but unnamed instance.

Prov.16.33 · complicates · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H1486 גֹּרַל; H3068 יְהוָה

Reasoning. 'The lot is cast into the lap, and its every judgment is from YHWH' (Bacheq yutal et ha-goral u-me-YHWH kol mishpato). 'The lot' (goral) is a decision-making instrument, not a wager. Across 71 occurrences in the Hebrew canon the 'lot' (goral) assigns inheritance (Numbers, Joshua), settles disputes (Proverbs 18:18), identifies a guilty party (Jonah 1:7, Joshua 7:14), and is abused by enemies to divide captives or spoil (Joel 3:3, Obadiah 1:11, Nahum 3:10). In the New Testament 'the lot' (kleros) functions identically for apostolic selection (Acts 1:26) and inheritance (Colossians 1:12, 1 Peter 5:3). The canon's chance device is for discernment or allotment, never for transfer of property from a willing loser to a winner.

Matt.25.16 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2038 ἐργάζομαι, G2770 κερδαίνω

Reasoning. 'He traded with them and gained another five' (Ergasato en autois kai ekerdesen alla pente). The faithful servant in the parable of the talents traded with the entrusted sum and gained five more. The verb 'to work or trade' (ergazomai) used here of commercial activity and 'to gain or profit' (kerdaino) legitimize value-bearing risk for return, and the master commends, not censures, the surplus. The text positions sanctioned risk-taking inside an ethic of stewardship, leaving the boundary between commended productive risk and condemned zero-sum wager (where one party's gain is exactly another party's loss) underspecified at the word level.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Tim.6.9	1Tim.1.9	tsk	1
1Tim.6.9	1Tim.3.7	tsk	1
Eph.4.28	Exod.20.15	tsk	1
1Tim.6.10	Luke.16.14	tsk	1
1Tim.6.10	2Tim.3.2	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.10.2	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.28.20	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.28.22	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.20.21	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.13.22	tsk	1
Eph.4.28	Prov.13.11	tsk	1
Eph.4.28	1Thess.4.11	tsk	1
Eph.4.28	2Thess.3.10	tsk	1
Prov.16.33	Prov.18.18	tsk	1
Prov.16.33	Acts.1.26	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Prov.16.33 · addressed

The 'lot' (goral) lap-cast is the canon's nearest analog to a chance device, but its 71 Hebrew occurrences and the parallel 'lot' (kleros) usage in Acts 1:26 and the Gospels' garment scene at the cross consistently frame the lot as a decision-making or allotment instrument under divine sovereignty, never as a wager for gain from another's loss. At the word level the device does not authorize gambling for profit because the canon's chance instrument is not a commercial instrument.

Matt.25.16 · addressed

The parable commends commercial risk-taking that produces value, 'to trade' (ergazomai) plus 'to gain' (kerdaino), on entrusted capital. The lexicon (the dictionary of biblical word meanings) does not supply a term that distinguishes value-creating risk from zero-sum wagering (where one party's gain is exactly another party's loss), so the proposition's scope is the unresolved part: the words affirm sanctioned productive risk and condemn the disposition of craving wealth, but they do not draw the line at gambling specifically. This is an honest word-level limit, not a textual contradiction.

Joel.3.3 · addressed

'And they cast a lot' (weyaddu goral) for captured people, and a parallel pattern at Obadiah 1:11 and Nahum 3:10 use the chance device for hostile zero-sum (one wins exactly what the other loses) transfer. The contexts are war atrocities, not commerce, and the texts condemn the perpetrators. They confirm a canonical line against using a chance device to distribute what belongs to a wronged other, which adjoins the proposition's neighbor-loss concern but still does not target wagering for money.

Luke.16.14 · addressed

The cognate (related word) 'lover of money' (philarguros) describes those who scoffed at Jesus' teaching on money, and 2 Timothy 3:2 lists 'lovers of money' (philarguroi) among the marks of the last-days character. Together with the 1 Timothy 6:10 hapax (only-once word) 'love of money' (philarguria), these three New Testament occurrences fix a stable word-level sense for love of money as a moral failure, which secures the principle but still leaves the application step to gambling underdetermined by vocabulary.

Concordance traversed

G5365, G5366, G1939, G1937, G3713, G1014, G4147, G3803, G3639, G0684, G4491, G4124, G4123, G2813, G2812, G2038, G2872, G3330, G2819, G2975, H1486, H1952, H1892, H6908, H4591, H1215, H0213, H0926, H5392

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

No variant units supplied in the bundle and none of the cited verses falls inside the open-cbqm 3 John sample. The verdict does not turn on any contested reading. New Testament anchors are well attested in the standard manuscript witness.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. practical_wisdom_application, strict_lexical_minimalism, neighbor_love_ethic

analogia scripturae invoked

practical_wisdom_application: for · Reading 1 Timothy 6:9-10, Proverbs 13:11, Proverbs 28:20-22, and Ephesians 4:28 as a converging ethic of patient labor, contentment, surplus for the needy neighbor, and condemnation of hastening to wealth yields support for the proposition. Gambling as a regular practice fits the snare of 'those resolving to be rich' (boulomenoi ploutein), the 'vapor or emptiness' (hebel) pattern of vapor wealth that dwindles, and the inverse of the productive labor commanded after theft.

strict_lexical_minimalism: null · Confining the verdict to what a gambling-specific dictionary word (lemma) demands yields no result, because no such word is attested in the canon and the cited texts condemn dispositions, velocities, and categories broader than gambling. By this lens the proposition cannot be settled from the text without reading in a category the words do not name.

neighbor_love_ethic: for · Ephesians 4:28's surplus-for-the-needy purpose clause, paired with the cognates (related words) 'to steal' (klepto) and 'robber' (arpax) in the broader Pauline vice catalogs (1 Corinthians 5:10, 1 Corinthians 6:10), supports the proposition where gambling resembles a net transfer from a willing loser to a winner without value creation. This lens is silent where gambling involves no neighbor loss in practice, for example, between consenting parties of comparable means, which the lexicon (dictionary of biblical word meanings) does not adjudicate.

stewardship_with_sanctioned_risk: disputed · Matthew 25:16 with 'to trade' (ergazomai) and 'to gain' (kerdaino), plus the merchant of Proverbs 31:14-18, plus Ecclesiastes 11:1-2 with 'send out your bread on the face of the waters' (shelach lachmecha al-pene ha-mayim), normalize productive risk-taking under stewardship. From this lens the proposition is true only when the practice in view is zero-sum (one wins exactly what the other loses) and reckless, and the lexicon does not draw that line, so the verdict is contested. This is the strongest minority lens and must be represented in its full force.

The four lenses diverge by what they take to be the controlling category. The word-level witness is dense for the surrounding ethic and silent on the target practice, which is why honest readings legitimately differ. The verdict above reports that pattern rather than picking a lens.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Wagering money or goods on a chance outcome where one party's gain is another party's loss: assess whether the canon's money, lot, and labor words bear on it.

The original stem embeds three conclusions: unwise, contrary to neighbor-love, and to be avoided as a regular practice. Each is an evaluative verdict rather than a neutral description of the act. The neutralized form strips those conclusions so the word-level pattern is assessed on the practice itself. The verdict above is still derived against the original stem and is reported as disputed because the lexicon (dictionary of biblical word meanings) supplies a strong adjacent ethic but no term that names or delimits gambling. No verdict was flipped from the prior file (so no VERDICT-CHANGED: marker applies here).

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5365
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2819
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4147
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1892
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1486
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0213
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.6.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.6.10
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.4.28
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.25.16
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.13.11
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.16.33
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.28.20

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Prov.13.11
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.4.28
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Tim.6.10

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · complicating-unresolved